

Working Out Difficult Words in Context — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: 15 min

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — THE CONTEXT CLUES CHECKLIST

THE RULE

You do not need to know every word to answer a question about it. The sentence and paragraph **around** a difficult word almost always contain a clue to its meaning. Never skip the question just because the word is unfamiliar.

THE TECHNIQUE — 4 STEPS

1. **Don't panic** — read the whole sentence (and the one before/after) first, ignoring the hard word
2. **Look for a clue type** in the surrounding text (see table below)
3. **Check word parts** — does a prefix, root, or suffix look familiar? (e.g. "un-" = not, "-less" = without)
4. **Test your guess** — substitute your guessed meaning back into the sentence. Does it still make sense?

TYPES OF CONTEXT CLUE

CLUE TYPE	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Synonym clue	A nearby word that means roughly the same thing
Contrast clue	A word like "but," "although," "unlike" signalling the opposite meaning nearby
Example clue	"such as," "for example," "like" followed by examples that explain it
General sense clue	No direct clue word, but the overall situation tells you the mood/meaning

2 · WORKED EXAMPLE

"Although her older brother was gregarious, chatting to everyone at the party within minutes, Priya hung back near the door, saying nothing."

STEP 1 Read the whole sentence: it's comparing two people's behaviour at a party.

STEP 2 "Although" signals a **contrast clue** — gregarious must be the opposite of Priya hanging back and saying nothing.

STEP 4 Guess: outgoing / very sociable. Test it: "her older brother was very sociable, chatting to everyone" — makes sense.

3 · PRACTICE PASSAGE

Underlined words are the ones to work out from context — do not look them up.

- 1 The old bridge had always looked **precarious**, its wooden planks warped and one handrail missing entirely, but generations of villagers had crossed it without incident, so nobody thought much of it. Dev's

grandmother, however, would only cross holding the remaining rail with both hands, muttering about how it wasn't built to last another winter.

2 When the council finally announced the bridge's **demolition**, replacing it with a proper concrete crossing, most of the village was relieved — except for a small, vocal group who argued the old bridge was part of the village's history and shouldn't be torn down for something so **utilitarian** and forgettable.

1. Using context clues, what does "precarious" most likely mean? Which clue type helped you decide?

2. What does "demolition" mean here? Point to the exact phrase later in the sentence that gives this away.

3. "Utilitarian" is contrasted with the idea of the bridge being part of the village's history. Using this contrast, explain what "utilitarian" most likely means.

4. Test your own understanding: rewrite the phrase "so utilitarian and forgettable" using a simpler word instead of "utilitarian," keeping the sentence's meaning the same.

Apply this every time: Whenever you hit a word you don't know in a comprehension passage, don't stop — read on to the end of the sentence first. The answer is usually hiding in the words around it, not the word itself.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

- Q1:** Unsafe/unstable/dangerous-looking. General sense clue — warped planks, missing handrail, grandmother's careful behaviour all support this.
- Q2:** Being torn down/knocked down. Example/synonym clue: "replacing it with a proper concrete crossing" and "torn down" later confirm this.
- Q3:** Purely practical/functional, with no charm or sentimental value — contrasted directly against "part of the village's history."
- Q4:** Any reasonable simpler synonym, e.g. "so plain and forgettable" or "so purely functional and forgettable" — mark on meaning preserved, not exact wording.